

Jayesh Limaye and Michael Browne

A speaker set has become an essential part of a computer system today. Historically, the term "computer speaker" conjures up an image of a tiny, tinny set sitting tamely by a monitor. But as the man once claimed, the times are a-changing, and speakers today are a galaxy away from their predecessors, with more watts than warts and greater clarity than many a hi-fi music system available today. In an era where widescreen displays and graphics cards have brought DVD-quality visuals to the desktop, 5.1 speakers bring in the aural content for a truly cinematic experience.

We demand realistic sound, be it in movies, our music or our games. We expect immersion: an explosion should rock the seat; gunfire should trigger a reflexive duck. Sound cards offer features such as DTS 96/24, THX, EAX Advanced HD and so on. To take advantage of these, one needs a good set of speakers, and

whether you invest in a set of stereo speakers or a multi channel system depends on your usage patterns.

For this test, we received 45 speaker sets from 13 brands. The usual suspects were present, along with new entrants such as Xfree, Umax and Gigabyte. Altec Lansing was present in force, and had eight models spanning the 2.1 and 5.1 categories. Gigabyte and Umax were the least-represented with just one model each. The speakers ranged from 2.1 stereo speakers to high end 6-channel sets. On to the show!

SOUND ON A BUDGET (2.1)

If you are on a budget, or are not too interested in multi-channel games or a home theatre setup, a 2.1-speaker set

should do fine. These speakers are meant to play stereo music, and they generally deliver better quality music than an ordinary 5.1 set. We have mentioned the reason for this in the box titled *2.1 or surround sound—What do you really need?* Although 2.1 speakers are not actually stereo in the strictest sense of the term, due to the subwoofer, they produce the stereo left and right channels, with the subwoofer handling the low frequencies. We therefore expect them to perform better in our music tests than with games and movies. We received a total of 27 speakers from 13 manufacturers in this category.

A Look At Features

A 2.1 speaker set is generally light on features, and offers more value for money by sacrificing on the functionality that their multi-channel brethren offer.

Of the units we tested, most did not bundle a remote control, the Altec Lansing MX-5021 and FX-6021 were the only 2.1 models to come with wired control pods

Imaging Pradip Ingale
Photograph Jiten Gandhi
Model Zoltan